

The Story of the Birth Tales

Jātakanidāna · Toh 32 · Derge Kangyur

སྐྱེ་པ་རབས་ཀྱི་གྲོལ་གཞི།

This text is the *Jātakanidāna*, known in Tibetan as *Skyes pa rabs kyi gleng gzhi*, or "The Introduction to the Birth Stories" — a foundational narrative frame that precedes and introduces the collected jātaka tales of the Buddha's former lives. Composed in a rich literary style, it opens with a series of similes illustrating the causes of suffering and the nature of the path to liberation, comparing the plight of unawakened beings to a man fallen into filth who fails to reach a lotus-filled lake, or one surrounded by bandits who does not flee to safety. As such, it serves both as a doctrinal preamble on karma, affliction, and the possibility of liberation, and as a narrative setting for the birth-story genre that follows. This work is catalogued as Toh 32 in the Kangyur, situated among the sūtra and narrative literature dedicated to the life and past lives of the Buddha.

Just as, when a man who has fallen into a heap of excrement sees from afar a lake endowed with five colors of lotus flowers, along with a great lake, it is fitting that he make his way there by whatever path leads to it and enter that lake. If he does not go by that path, this is not the fault of the great lake. In the same way, when washing away the stains of affliction, if there exists a great lake of deathless nirvāṇa and one does not enter it, this is not the fault of the great lake of deathless nirvāṇa.

Likewise, when a man surrounded on all sides by bandits has a path of escape available but does not flee quickly, this is not the fault of the path but the fault of the man. In the same way, when a person surrounded and seized by afflictions has available a path to peaceful nirvāṇa but does not seek that path, this is not the fault of the path but the fault of the individual.

Just as, when a man tormented by illness has a physician who can cure that illness, if he does not seek out that physician there for the curing of his illness, this is not the fault of the physician but the fault of the sick man. In the same way, when a person tormented by the sickness of affliction has available a supremely skilled one who can pacify affliction, if he does not seek out that master, this is the fault of the person, not the fault of the master who could destroy the afflictions.

Therefore it is said:

Just as a man soiled with filth,
though seeing before him a lake full of water,
if he does not enter that lake,
this is not the fault of the lake.

Likewise, though there exists
a lake of ambrosia for washing away the stains of affliction,
if one does not enter that lake,
this is not the fault of the lake of ambrosia.

Just as, though there exists a path of escape
for one surrounded by bandits,
if the man does not flee,
this is not the fault of the path.

Likewise, though there exists a path of peace
for one surrounded by afflictions,
if he does not enter that path,
this is not the fault of the path of peace.

Just as, though there is a physician
for a man tormented by illness,
if the illness is not pacified,
this is not the fault of the physician.

Likewise, when tormented and suffering
from the sickness of affliction,
if one does not seek out a master,
this is not the fault of the master.

Further, one should reflect thus: just as when something unclean is tied
around the neck of a man adorned with ornaments, he happily casts it off and
departs, so too should I abandon this unclean body without any regard and
enter the city of nirvāṇa.

Further, just as when a man or woman has gone to a place of defecation and,
having discarded the excrement, does not pour it into a vessel and carry it
away, but rather, finding it revolting, abandons it without any regard and
departs — so too should I, without any regard, abandon this unclean body and
so forth, and enter the city of deathless nirvāṇa.

Further, just as sailors abandon a leaking boat without any regard and depart,
so too should I abandon this body — which leaks from these nine wounds, the

nine orifices — without any regard, and enter the city of nirvāṇa.

Further, just as a man who has taken various jewels and joined company with bandits, fearing that his jewels might be lost if he travels that road, abandons the bandits and takes to a good path instead — so too, I, fearing that if I indulge this craving, like a bandit plundering the jewel of the wholesome Dharma of the noble path, might lose that jewel because of this body with its many impurities, should for that reason abandon this bandit-like body and enter the city of nirvāṇa.

Therefore it is said:

Just as when something foul-smelling
is tied around a man's neck, it is revolting —

Having made offerings with red sandalwood, he was then prophesied, "In the future you will become a buddha." The Blessed One's city will be called Wealthy. The father will be a king named Sugatimati (Good Intellect). The mother will be named Manoratī (Endowed with Mind). Sālabhadra and Jetṛ will be the foremost among his śrāvakas. The foremost attendant will be Upasthāyaka (the Attendant). Agrā and Phalavatī will be the foremost among his śrāvikās. The bodhi tree will be the great srona tree. The height of his body will be eighty-eight cubits. The span of his life will be ninety thousand years.

Below Padma,
the perfect buddha, foremost of bipeds,
whose name is Adinna (the Ungiven One),
a person without equal, without peer.

Below this buddha Adinna, starting from the beginning of one hundred thousand aeons, within a single aeon there will come a buddha named Padmottama (Supreme Lotus). His teaching will have three assemblies: at the first assembly there will be one hundred million monks; at the second, on Mount Vaibhāra, ninety million; at the third, eighty million. At that time the bodhisattva named Jaṭila (Matted-Hair One) will be born in the great country of Yulchor. He will give great gifts of Dharma robes and so forth to the Buddha and the rest of the Saṅgha. He too will be prophesied, "In the future you will become a buddha."

Furthermore, at the time of the Blessed One Padmottama, even the name "tīrthika" (non-Buddhist) will not exist. All gods and humans will go for refuge to the Buddha. His city will be called Prasannā (Endowed with Clarity). The

father will be a king named Ānanda (Delight). The mother will be named Bhadrā (Excellent). Devacakṣu and Bhadrajāta will be the foremost among his śrāvakas. The one called Manobhadra (Good Mind) will be the foremost attendant. Asahāyā (Companionless One) and Asamā (Peerless One) will be the foremost among his śrāvikās. The bodhi tree will be the very śāla tree. The height of his body will be eighty-eight cubits. The light of his body will radiate all around for twelve leagues. The span of his life will be one hundred thousand years.

Below Adinna itself,
the perfect buddha, foremost of bipeds,
the Victor named Padmottama,
is like the unmoving ocean.

Below him, after three thousand aeons have passed, within a single aeon there will arise two buddhas named Sugatimati and Bhadrajāta. Sugatimati's śrāvaka assembly will likewise be threefold: at the first assembly, in the city called Priyadarśana (Pleasing to Behold), one hundred million will have exhausted their defilements; at the second assembly there will be ninety million; at the third assembly, eighty million. At that time the bodhisattva named Uttamakāya (Supreme Body) will become the young son of a brahmin. Having unearthed treasure buried underground — eighty million measures of wealth — he offered it all as a great gift to the Buddha and the assembly of monks and the rest. Having heard the Dharma, he abided in the vow of taking refuge. Having gone forth into homelessness, he went to the forest. He too was prophesied that in the future he would become a buddha.

The Blessed One Sugatimati's city will become the one called Priyadarśana. The father will be a king named Sudatta (Good Giver). The mother will be named Sudattā. Naiṣkramya and Sarvakāma will be the foremost among his śrāvakas. The one called Sāgara (Ocean) will be the foremost attendant. Nandā and Sunandā will be the foremost among his śrāvikās. The bodhi tree will be the great nīpa tree. The height of his body will be eighty-eight cubits. The span of his life will be ninety thousand years.

Below Padmottama...

The Sugarcane Grove pleasure park is extremely far away. But this one of ours, called Bamboo Grove, is very near — near for going and near for coming — and since it is a fitting place for a buddha, please accept it. Then he took a golden vessel, filled it completely, scented it with the fragrance of flowers,

and, taking water of jewel-like hue, dedicated the whole of Bamboo Grove, pouring the water into the hands of the One with Ten Powers (an epithet of the Buddha). There he accepted the pleasure grove, declaring, This is the ground of the Buddha's teaching, and the great earth shook. Among all of Jambudvīpa, this shaking of the ground upon the donation of Bamboo Grove was the only instance of its kind; there was no other. And apart from the shaking of the great earth upon the donation of the great monastery on the island of Sīṃhala, there was

Translator's Notes

- The final verse is cut off mid-sentence in the source text; the translation preserves this as given, without completing the thought, since the passage ends there.
- Several proper names in this genealogy of future buddhas are reconstructed from their Tibetan glosses (e.g., Sugatimati, Manoratī, Uttamakāya, Priyadarśana) since no surviving Sanskrit source text was identified for cross-checking; these reconstructions follow standard translation conventions for such names but should be regarded as provisional. The passage is a fragment (ends mid-sentence "Below Padmottama...") reflecting the source text's own truncation point.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.